Introduction to Algorithms

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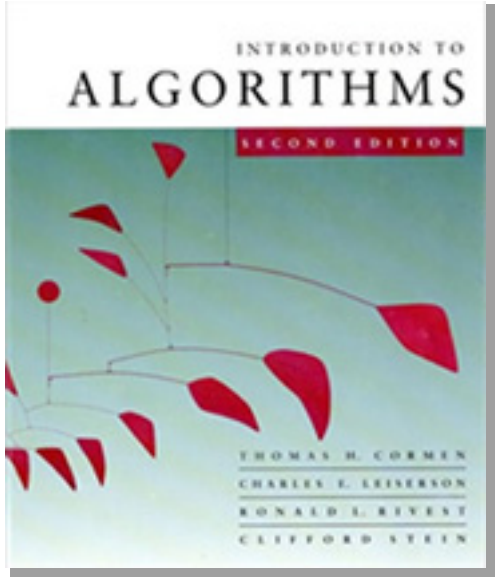

LECTURE 2

Asymptotic Notation

- O-, Ω-, and Θ-notation

Recurrences

- Substitution method
- Iterating the recurrence
- Recursion tree
- Master method

Prof. Erik Demaine

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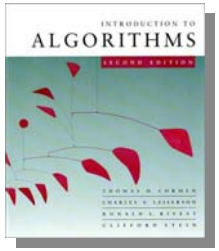

Asymptotic notation

O-notation (upper bounds):

We write $f(n) = O(g(n))$ if there exist constants $c > 0$, $n_0 > 0$ such that $0 \le f(n) \le cg(n)$ for all $n \ge n_0$.

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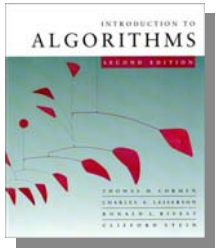

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EXAMPLE: $2n^2 = O(n^3)$ $\quad (c = 1, n_0 = 2)$

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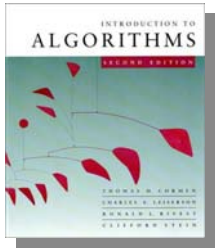

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functions, not values

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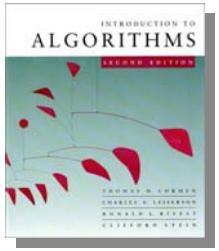

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functions, not values

funny, "one-way" equality

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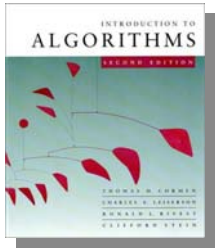

Set definition of O-notation

$O(g(n)) = \{ f(n) :$ there exist constants $c > 0$, $n_0 > 0$ such that $0 \le f(n) \le cg(n)$ for all $n \ge n_0 \}$

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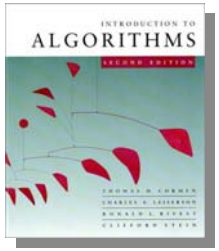

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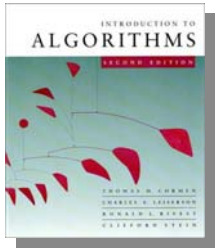

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EXAMPLE: $2n^2 \in O(n^3)$

(*Logicians*: $\lambda n.2n^2 \in O(\lambda n.n^3)$, but it's convenient to be sloppy, as long as we understand what's *really* going on.)

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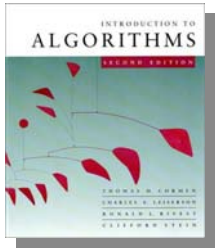

Macro substitution

Convention: A set in a formula represents an anonymous function in the set.

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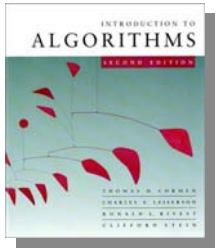

Macro substitution

Convention: A set in a formula represents an anonymous function in the set.

EXAMPLE: $f(n) = n^3 + O(n^2)$

means

$f(n) = n^3 + h(n)$

for some $h(n) \in O(n^2)$.

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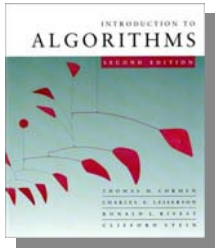

Macro substitution

Convention: A set in a formula represents an anonymous function in the set.

EXAMPLE: $n^2 + O(n) = O(n^2)$

means

for any $f(n) \in O(n)$:

$$n^2 + f(n) = h(n)$$

for some $h(n) \in O(n^2)$.

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Ω-notation (lower bounds)

O-notation is an *upper-bound* notation. It makes no sense to say $f(n)$ is at least $O(n^2)$.

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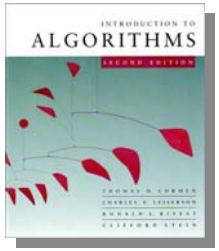

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$\Omega(g(n)) = \{ f(n)$: there exist constants $c > 0$, $n_0 > 0$ such that $0 \le cg(n) \le f(n)$ for all $n \ge n_0 \}$

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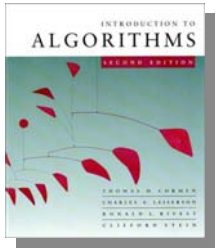

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EXAMPLE: $\sqrt{n} = \Omega(\lg n)$ $(c = 1, n_0 = 16)$

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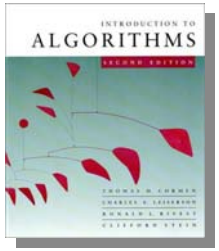

Θ-notation (tight bounds)

$$\Theta(g(n)) = O(g(n)) \cap \Omega(g(n))$$

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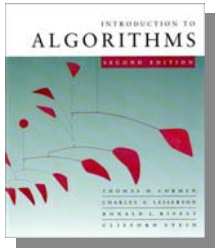

Θ-notation (tight bounds)

$$\Theta(g(n)) = O(g(n)) \cap \Omega(g(n))$$

EXAMPLE: $\frac{1}{2}n^2 - 2n = \Theta(n^2)$

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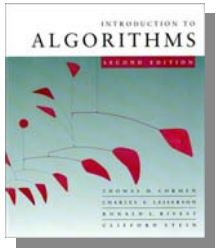

o-notation and ω-notation

O-notation and Ω-notation are like $\leq$ and $\geq$.
o-notation and ω-notation are like $<$ and $>$.

$o(g(n)) = \{ f(n) :$ for any constant $c > 0$,
there is a constant $n_0 > 0$
such that $0 \leq f(n) < cg(n)$
for all $n \geq n_0 \}$

EXAMPLE: $2n^2 = o(n^3)$ $(n_0 = 2/c)$

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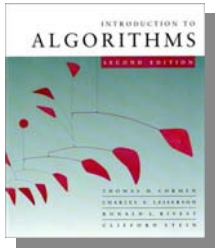

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$\omega(g(n)) = \{ f(n) :$ for any constant $c > 0$,
there is a constant $n_0 > 0$
such that $0 \leq cg(n) < f(n)$
for all $n \geq n_0 \}$

EXAMPLE: $\sqrt{n} = \omega(\lg n)$ $\quad (n_0 = 1+1/c)$

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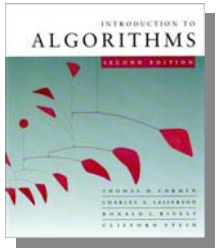

Solving recurrences

- The analysis of merge sort from ***Lecture 1*** required us to solve a recurrence.
- Recurrences are like solving integrals, differential equations, etc.
  - Learn a few tricks.
- ***Lecture 3***: Applications of recurrences to divide-and-conquer algorithms.

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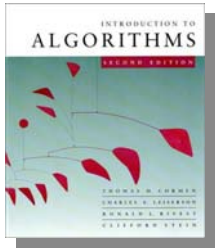

Substitution method

The most general method:

1. ***Guess*** the form of the solution.
2. ***Verify*** by induction.
3. ***Solve*** for constants.

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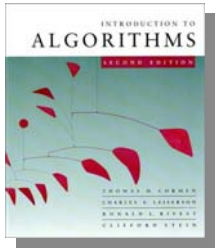

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1. ***Guess*** the form of the solution.
2. ***Verify*** by induction.
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EXAMPLE: $T(n) = 4T(n/2) + n$

- [Assume that $T(1) = \Theta(1)$.]
- Guess $O(n^3)$. (Prove O and Ω separately.)
- Assume that $T(k) \le ck^3$ for $k < n$.
- Prove $T(n) \le cn^3$ by induction.

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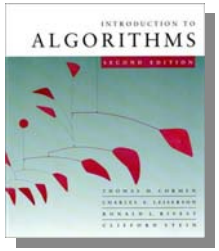

Example of substitution

$$
\begin{aligned}
T(n) &= 4T(n/2) + n \\
&\le 4c(n/2)^3 + n \\
&= (c/2)n^3 + n \\
&= cn^3 - ((c/2)n^3 - n) \leftarrow \textit{desired} - \textit{residual} \\
&\le cn^3 \leftarrow \textit{desired}
\end{aligned}
$$

whenever $(c/2)n^3 - n \ge 0$, for example, if $c \ge 2$ and $n \ge 1$.

residual

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Example (continued)

- We must also handle the initial conditions, that is, ground the induction with base cases.
- ***Base:*** $T(n) = \Theta(1)$ for all $n < n_0$, where n_0 is a suitable constant.
- For $1 \le n < n_0$, we have "$\Theta(1)$" $\le cn^3$, if we pick c big enough.

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- For $1 \le n < n_0$, we have "$\Theta(1)$" $\le cn^3$, if we pick c big enough.

This bound is not tight!

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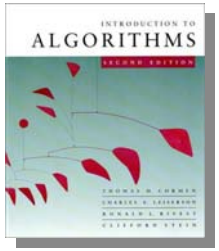

A tighter upper bound?

We shall prove that $T(n) = O(n^2)$.

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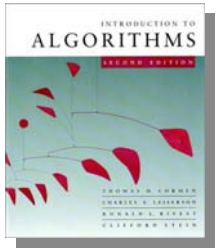

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We shall prove that $T(n) = O(n^2)$.

Assume that $T(k) \le ck^2$ for $k < n$:

$$
\begin{aligned}
T(n) &= 4T(n/2) + n \\
&\le 4c(n/2)^2 + n \\
&= cn^2 + n \\
&= O(n^2)
\end{aligned}
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\end{aligned}
$$

Wrong! We must prove the I.H.

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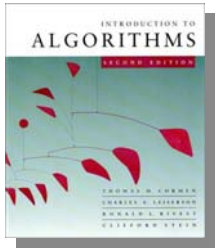

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\begin{aligned}
T(n) &= 4T(n/2) + n \\
&\le 4c(n/2)^2 + n \\
&= cn^2 + n \\
&= \cancel{O(n^2)} \quad \textbf{\textit{Wrong!}}\ \text{We must prove the I.H.} \\
&= cn^2 - (-n) \quad [\ \text{desired} - \text{residual}\ ] \\
&\le cn^2 \quad \text{for } \textbf{\textit{no}} \text{ choice of } c > 0. \text{ Lose!}
\end{aligned}
$$

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A tighter upper bound!

IDEA: Strengthen the inductive hypothesis.

- ***Subtract*** a low-order term.

Inductive hypothesis: $T(k) \le c_1 k^2 - c_2 k$ for $k < n$.

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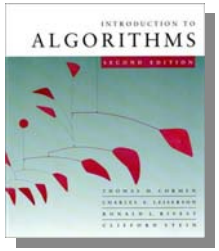

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Inductive hypothesis: $T(k) \le c_1 k^2 - c_2 k$ for $k < n$.

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\begin{aligned}
T(n) &= 4T(n/2) + n \\
&= 4(c_1(n/2)^2 - c_2(n/2)) + n \\
&= c_1 n^2 - 2c_2 n + n \\
&= c_1 n^2 - c_2 n - (c_2 n - n) \\
&\le c_1 n^2 - c_2 n \quad \text{if } c_2 \ge 1.
\end{aligned}
$$

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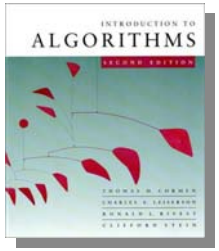

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Inductive hypothesis: $T(k) \le c_1 k^2 - c_2 k$ for $k < n$.

$$\begin{aligned} T(n) &= 4T(n/2) + n \\ &= 4(c_1(n/2)^2 - c_2(n/2)) + n \\ &= c_1 n^2 - 2c_2 n + n \\ &= c_1 n^2 - c_2 n - (c_2 n - n) \\ &\le c_1 n^2 - c_2 n \quad \text{if } c_2 \ge 1. \end{aligned}$$

Pick c_1 big enough to handle the initial conditions.

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